

An Inquiry into Forms of the Possible

Center for Possible Minds Reading Group — Spring 2026

Organizers: Justin Stec and Jacob Foster

Wednesdays, 4:00–5:30 PM

First Meeting: February 4, 2026

All texts provided by the organizers. Participants from all disciplinary backgrounds welcome.

UNIT I: ANCIENT AND MEDIEVAL FOUNDATIONS

Week 1 — February 4: Parmenides (~40 pp.)

How can we think or speak “what is not”? This problem drives subsequent responses from Aristotle through Heidegger. Kingsley’s reading situates Parmenides within an initiatory tradition.

Parmenides, “On Nature” (complete fragments, ~10 pp.)

Peter Kingsley, *In the Dark Places of Wisdom*, chapters 1–4 (~30 pp.)

Week 2 — February 11: Aristotle (~45 pp.)

Aristotle’s potentiality (*dynamis*) answers Parmenides by locating possibility within beings themselves. Avicenna and Heidegger will both transform this vocabulary. The sea-battle problem asks whether future contingents have determinate truth values.

Aristotle, *Metaphysics* Book Theta, chapters 1–3 and 6–8 (~30 pp.)

Aristotle, *De Interpretatione*, chapter 9 (~5 pp.)

Charlotte Witt, “The Priority of Actuality in Aristotle” (~10 pp.)

Week 3 — February 18: Avicenna (~40 pp.)

Separating essence from existence, Avicenna makes contingency fundamental to everything except the Necessary Existent. This reconfiguration of Aristotle shapes Leibniz’s later work on possible worlds and sufficient reason.

Avicenna, *The Metaphysics of The Healing*, Book I chapters 5–6, Book VIII chapters 1–3 (~25 pp.)

Peter Adamson, “From the Necessary Existent to God” (~15 pp.)

Week 4 — February 25: Nagarjuna (~40 pp.)

Does “possibility” mean anything once inherent existence drops out? Nagarjuna’s tetralemma refuses the logical options that Western frameworks take for granted, and the contemplative science readings in Unit IV will return to this question.

Nagarjuna, *Mulamadhyamakakarika*, chapters 1, 15, 24 (Garfield trans., ~20 pp.)

Jay Garfield, “Dependent Arising and the Emptiness of Emptiness” (~20 pp.)

Unit I Workshop — February 26 or 27

UNIT II: RATIONALISM, TRANSCENDENTALISM, AND THE IMAGINAL

Week 5 — March 4: Leibniz and Du Châtelet (~35 pp.)

Compossibility constrains which possibilities can coexist within a single world. The *Monadology* raises the question of what individuates possible worlds and whether they exist independently of minds; the *Institutions de physique* systematizes Leibniz-Wolffian metaphysics while defending the principle of sufficient reason against Newtonian criticisms.

Leibniz, *Monadology* (~15 pp.)

Émilie du Châtelet, *Institutions de physique*, chapters 1–2 (~15 pp.)

Leibniz, “On the Ultimate Origination of Things” (~5 pp., selections)

Week 6 — March 11: Kant and Contemporary Kantian Modality (~45 pp.)

What must any possible experience conform to? Kant’s Postulates distinguish logical possibility from real possibility. Leech’s “modal transcendentalism” develops this framework for contemporary debates about necessity and essence.

Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*: “Postulates of Empirical Thought” (A218–235/B265–287, ~20 pp.)

Jessica Leech, “The Function of Modal Judgment and the Kantian Gap” (2018, ~25 pp.)

Week 7 — March 18: Sufi Metaphysics (~35 pp.) (Spring Break — informal)

Ibn Arabi’s imaginal world (alam al-mithal) occupies a realm between sensible and intelligible, where possibilities take on form. His framework transforms Avicenna’s essence/existence distinction and anticipates Leibniz’s concern with why these possibilities rather than others become actual. Rabia’s sayings mark an earlier moment in the tradition.

Rabia al-Adawiyya, selected sayings and poems (~5 pp.)

Ibn Arabi, *Fusus al-Hikam* (Bezels of Wisdom), “Adam” chapter (~10 pp., Austin or Dagli trans.)

William Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge*, chapter 1 (~20 pp.)

Unit II Workshop — March 19 or 20

UNIT III: PHENOMENOLOGY, PRAGMATISM, AND NOTHINGNESS

Week 8 — March 25: Husserl and Derrida (~45 pp.)

Can a condition of possibility also be a condition of impossibility? Derrida’s introduction to Husserl’s text works through this question by examining how ideal objects arise in history yet claim eternal validity.

Husserl, “The Origin of Geometry” (~20 pp.)

Derrida, *Introduction to “The Origin of Geometry”*, selections (~25 pp.)

Week 9 — April 1: Heidegger and Arendt (~45 pp.)

Heidegger transforms the Aristotelian vocabulary so that possibility becomes constitutive of Dasein; death individualizes as the ownmost possibility. Arendt’s natality—the capacity to begin something new—offers a counter-emphasis to Heidegger’s being-toward-death.

Heidegger, *Being and Time*, Division II chapter 1 (sections 46–53, ~30 pp.)

Arendt, *The Human Condition*, chapter 5 sections 24–26 (~15 pp.)

Week 10 — April 8: Peirce (~40 pp.)

Firstness is pure qualitative possibility, prior to relation or resistance. Peirce’s continuum allows possibility to grade into actuality, and his categories resurface in Whitehead’s process philosophy.

Peirce, “Some Consequences of Four Incapacities” (~20 pp.)

Peirce, “A Guess at the Riddle,” chapters 1–3 (~20 pp.)

Week 11 — April 15: Nothingness East and West (~35 pp.)

Nishida’s “place of absolute nothingness” (zettai mu no basho) holds particulars without being one itself. His synthesis of Zen Buddhism and Western phenomenology offers a different response to the Parmenidean problem than Aristotle’s. Lalla’s Kashmiri Shaivite poetry pursues nothingness through a different idiom.

Nishida Kitaro, *An Inquiry into the Good*, Part I chapters 1–3 (~25 pp.)

Lalla, *Naked Song*, selections (~10 pp.)

Unit III Workshop — April 17 or 18

UNIT IV: PROCESS, CONTEMPLATION, EMANATION

Week 12 — April 22: Whitehead (~45 pp.)

Eternal objects ingress into actual occasions as pure potentials. Whitehead’s God functions as the primordial envisagement of possibility, a role that recalls Leibniz, and Peirce’s categories find new form in this processual framework.

Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World*, chapter 11 (~25 pp.)

Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, Part I section 2.1 (~20 pp.)

Week 13 — April 29: Contemplative Science (~45 pp.)

Thompson and Varela bridge first-person contemplative methods and third-person neuroscience. The Buddhist concept of awareness (rigpa) may constitute a kind of possibility prior to Western categories, returning to questions Nagarjuna raised. Weil’s account of attention resonates with contemplative approaches while drawing on Platonic sources.

Evan Thompson, *Waking, Dreaming, Being*, chapter 1 (~20 pp.)

Simone Weil, “Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God” (~10 pp.)

Francisco Varela, “Neurophenomenology: A Methodological Remedy for the Hard Problem” (~15 pp.)

Week 14 — May 6: Neoplatonism (~40 pp.)

Possibility flows from the One’s inexhaustible superabundance. This emanationist framework shaped Avicenna and passed into German Idealism; it offers a counterpoint to the Aristotelian model of potentiality. Conway synthesizes Neoplatonic emanation with Kabbalistic and vitalist sources.

Plotinus, *Enneads* V.1 (~25 pp.)

Anne Conway, *Principles of the Most Ancient and Modern Philosophy*, selections (~15 pp.)

Unit IV Workshop — May 7 or 8

UNIT V: MATHEMATICAL AND FORMAL POSSIBILITY

Week 15 — May 13: Modal Logic and Set-Theoretic Potentialism (~60 pp.)

Ruth Barcan Marcus founded quantified modal logic; her Barcan formula raises questions about the relation between possibility and existence. Hamkins's multiverse holds many distinct concepts of set, each instantiated in a corresponding universe. Potentialism treats the hierarchy as indefinitely extensible, echoing Aristotle's claim that actuality precedes potentiality while reversing its valence.

Ruth Barcan Marcus, "Modalities and Intensional Languages" (1961, ~15 pp.)

Hamkins, "The Set-Theoretic Multiverse" (2012, ~25 pp.)

Hamkins and Linnebo, "The Modal Logic of Set-Theoretic Potentialism" (2022, ~20 pp.)

Week 16 — May 20: Foster (~40 pp.)

How do possibility spaces themselves get produced? Foster's work shows tradition constraining what becomes thinkable while furnishing materials for innovation, bringing the semester's philosophical questions into contact with computational and sociological methods.

Koch, Silvestro, and Foster, "The Evolutionary Dynamics of Cultural Change (As Told Through the Birth and Brutal, Blackened Death of Metal Music)" (SocArXiv preprint, ~40 pp.)

Unit V Workshop — May 21 or 22

WORKSHOPS

Five workshops (one per unit), Thursday or Friday evenings. Dates negotiable. For sharing drafts, extended discussion, collaborative work.